Blue Front

By Martha Collins

(Pg 3) He was five. He sold

fruit on the street

He sold fruit. People came

He made change

came to see him

make change

INTRODUCTION

Martha Collin's father, as a five-year-old boy, sold fruit in front of the Blue Front Restaurant in Cairo, Illinois, in November 1909. What he witnessed there and then, along with the reported 10,000 spectators, is shocking.

Blue Front by Martha Collins

(Pg 14) Welcome to Cairo

(Pg 4) the street was Commercial

Dowling Pressing

Saloon Drugstore Opera House

Three States Buggy Champion Tools

Blue Front Restaurant

4NG Fanatics

(Pg 5) a town where people lived

together black and white

(pg 64) Eleven White churches

Eleven black churches

(pg 5) couldn't look out the same

window couldn't read

the same books laundry

couldn't be washed

in the same machines

water came from the same

source but couldn't be drunk

from the same fountains

(pg 13) couldn't be sworn in

on the same Bible

(Pg 28) couldn't read the same books read only the others' old

couldn't be served in restaurants only backdoor take-out

kitchens

couldn't swim in the swimming pool or skate at the skating rink

(Pg 8) Springfield [247 miles away and a year earlier]

in 1908 a black was accused of killing a white another black of

raping a white

where in 1908 a mob finding the prisoners gone burned the
transporting car destroyed 24 black businesses 40 black homes
killed 2 successful black and also accidentally 4 whites

Where in 1908 events occurred that led a 1909 Cairo paper to
say its citizens *were not moved by race prejudice, nor did they*
permit themselves to be led into wanton destruction of property,
or the taking of innocent lives, as in Springfield

(Pg 9) my father he sold
fruit on the street

(pg 16) he sold fruit in front
of the Blue Front
he was five he could make change

(pg 10) someone must have held
him up his uncle his father's
shoulders so he could see

(Pg 17) 10,000 including children on parents' shoulders
who saw what occurred in November 1909

(Pg 19) it is supposed that it is believed that Miss
Anna Pelly Miss Annie Pelley Miss Anne
Miss Pelly age 24 age 22 who worked

4NG Fanatics

In the Pupkin Dry Good store and lived
an orphan who lived with her married sister

(Pg 9) my father
(**Pg 19)** was five would not have seen he could
have known the little girl who found
the body she was seven or three but that
would not have been till the next day

It is supposed she was assaulted on Elm
near her home it is believed she struck

(Pg 20) her assailant who gagged *with such*
cruel force it is thought he carried
her into the alley
the ground showed she was dragged
it is known she was outraged *not a doubt*
and strangled *a virgin unquestionably pure*

(Pg 21) said him because she was large and he
was larger he was large enough said
him because she was white and he
was black and could have therefore
must have necessarily him because

Was what they said it always was was why they said
they had to must but it wasn't always rape (alleged) it wasn't
always murder (alleged) it wasn't always even alleged

(Pg 22) bloodhounds got the scent
from the flour-sack cloth found
in the mouth led authorities

to Poplar Street then more
hounds more to the same place
and later all the way to the city jail

Where Will 'Froggie' James
Will the Frog Will alias Frog
who drove for Cairo Ice and Coal

Who stayed with Loving Green
who stayed with Georgia Cooper

To Poplar Street the house of Loving
Lovey Lovie Green a negress of bad repute
where James stayed she was found

Washing a cloth that exactly matches no
a similar cloth
Will James was arrested while driving his wagon

4NG Fanatics

(Pg 23) no scratches blood
no missing items

But Anna Pelley's sister said
he delivered ice last summer he
was insolent she had complained

(Pg 44) he was seventeen
once too he could have gone
to school Sumner High

(colored) had been in town
since the 1883 protests

But we do not know
if he went to school
above average intelligence
says a 1910 book but adds
for one of his race

(Pg 23) authorities are taking extraordinary precautions
to protect their prisoners because excitement
is high in all parts of Cairo

(Pg 3) [My father] was five.
(Pg 32) he wouldn't have seen the train
make an extra stop for the prisoner

who was spirited away from jail
and into the sheriff's hands

mutterings of lynchings heard all day
would he have heard?

there may be a lynching tonight

(Pg 33) at nine the mob went to the city
jail they searched the cells wooden and steel
struck matches threatened to lynch the police
chief and jailer if they would not produce

the mob was composed almost entirely of strangers

(Pg 32) there may be a lynching tonight

(Pg 38) hang

As a mirror on a wall, or the fall
of a dress.
to fasten to dry.
so the act of doing it
changes the verb, tense not
quite right. With rope, like a swing
from a tree, from a pole, like a flag

In the night, in the air

4NG Fanatics

(Pg 50) the victim hanged, though not on a tree

There were trees on those streets
trees that shaded the fenced-in yards of the large
Victorian houses
trees that were known to the crowd

Not on a tree
they used a steel arch
with electric lights, and later a lamppost, this
was a modern event, the trees were not involved.

(Pg 51) a crowd waited at Union Depot four
doors down from the Blue Front
(Pg 9) my father he sold
fruit on the street

(pg 16) he sold fruit in front
of the Blue Front

(pg 51) the prisoner
dragged to Eight and Commercial

would his father and uncle
have carried him joined

men women and children filled from side
to side the entire width of the 100-foot street
a wild rush flashes of gunfire shouts

Would he have understood
as they neared the arch
10,000 people massed together
a great angry wave of humanity shouted
'You dog! You black brute! Kill him! Burn him!'

Would he have understood

(pg 52) when someone turned on the lights on the arch
flooding the street the victim the crowd

He would have clearly seen

When they raised the victim
when the rope broke and the living body fell

he would have seen

when they dragged the victim fifty feet
shot 500 bullets into him dragged him heavy
to throw to the river but changed their minds

He would have seen

4NG Fanatics

When a woman lit the fire
while the crowd danced and shrieked

And while the body was burning they cut
off the half-burnt head cut open the chest cut
out the heart for souvenirs

He would have seen

When they placed the half-burnt head in a park
on a hitching post / a tire stick / a pole

He would have seen **(pg 55)** he was five

(pg 59) Children were often there they were being taught.

(pg 63)

[The Belleville Illinois News Democrat reported it this way on November 12, 1909]

In ferociously dramatic fashion the infuriated populace staged a tragedy. The pent-up fountains of human passion, human resentment, and human revenge broke forth. A so-called mob outbreak is as much a magnificent and grand natural phenomena as a cyclone or an earthquake, or a thunderbolt or a flood is, and it is much more unerring, more just and more terrible. The curtain has dropped. The band has ceased to play, the crowd is

gone, the lights are out, the house is dark and it is over. The outburst has done its work of purifying and of cleansing, and in that way it has fully accomplished its heaven-destined purpose.

(pg 64) Eleven White churches
Eleven black churches

Eleven white churches heard . . .

The failure of civil authorities
to maintain law and order

the lynchings it seems were necessary
to arouse the people to startle

the worst class of criminal
is the criminal negro, the worst
creature on earth, the politician
has patted this class on the head as one
pats a dog but you would not pat a mad
dog with your hand, you would use a club

The papers did not record
what was said in eleven black churches

(Pg 9) my father he sold
fruit on the street

4NG Fanatics

(pg 16) he sold fruit in front
of the Blue Front

He would have seen **(pg 55)** he was five

(pg 77) And the last day [the day before my father died]
he said You know
this would could be

A better place just

Promise me that you
will help he waited

(pg 16) he sold fruit in front
of the Blue Front

(pg 77) he made change may
I help you please
make change

4NG Fanatics

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Martha Collins
ISBN: 978-1555974497
Publisher: Graywolf Press
Date (Month/Year): May 2006

AWARD HISTORY

IL State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY